saffron kurta, I was looking forward to the dialogue. The topic was ‘Regional Identity and National Pride’. While Modi spoke eloquently on Mahatma Gandhi and development, I could not resist asking whether he had transformed from the politician of 2002 when he had been described by his opponents as a ‘hero of hatred’ and even a ‘mass murderer’. The question touched a raw nerve—a combative Modi questioned my credentials as an anchor and wondered whether I would ever change and be able to look beyond the post-Godhra riots even while my kurta colour had changed!

At least, Modi did not walk out of the gathering. Less than ten days later that’s precisely what happened when senior journalist Karan Thapar was interviewing him for CNN-IBN’s *Devil’s Advocate*. I had warned Karan before the interview that Modi was still very sensitive about Godhra and the riots and maybe he should broach the subject a little later in the interview. But Karan has a deserved reputation as a bit of a bulldog interviewer—relentless, unsparing and direct. Less than a minute or two into the interview, he raised the question of Modi’s critics viewing him as a mass murderer despite his reputation as an efficient administrator, and whether he would express any regret over the handling of the riots. There was only one way the interview was going from that point on. Asking for a glass of water, Modi removed his microphone, thanked Karan and ended the interview. ‘The friendship should continue. You came here. I am happy and thankful to you. These are your ideas, you go on expressing these. I can’t do this interview. Three–four questions I have already enjoyed. No more, please,’ was the final word.

The walkout might have embarrassed any other politician. Not Modi. When I rang him up a short while later, his response was typically sharp. ‘You people continue with your business, I will continue to do mine.’ The Gujarat assembly election campaign was about to begin and Modi wasn’t going to be seen to be taking a step backwards.

A few days later, Sonia Gandhi on the campaign trail said those ‘ruling Gujarat are liars, dishonest and *maut ka saudagar*’ (merchant of death). Modi was enraged. It was one thing for a journalist to refer to him as a mass murderer in an interview, quite another for the Congress president to call